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That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, morning shower, afternoon thunderstorm, humid, high 78. **Tonight**, evening storm, low 72. **Tomorrow**, heavy afternoon thunderstorm, high 92. Weather map, Page B16.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



DANIEL BEREHULAK/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Uncertain Road Ahead

Nabatieh, a city that had come to symbolize southern Lebanon’s prosperous rise, now speaks to the nation’s worst fears. Page A9.

Trump Seeds Ballot Doubts In Fall Preview

By JONATHAN SWAN
and MAGGIE HABERMAN

WASHINGTON — For President Trump, any Democratic election victory is suspicious on its face. Even, apparently, in one of the most liberal cities in America. “Not possible for Spencer Pratt to have lost the L.A. runoffs after the big lead he had,” Mr. Trump wrote on social media on Monday. “3rd World Nation.”

On election night last Tuesday, Mr. Pratt — the reality-television personality and Trump-endorsed Republican — led the progressive city councilwoman Nithya Raman for second place to advance to November’s mayoral runoff, behind the incumbent, Mayor Karen Bass, who is also a Democrat.

But as election officials spent the following week counting late-arriving mail ballots, which were disproportionately from Democrats, Ms. Raman edged ahead of Mr. Pratt. On Monday evening, The Associated Press said that she had indeed prevailed.

Such fleeting Republican leads are common enough to have a name — the “red mirage” — yet Mr. Trump, as he did in his own 2020 loss, cast the slow count as proof of theft. By baselessly framing Ms. Raman’s rise as a Democratic scam, Mr. Trump extended his long-running project to erode public faith in elections — and gave an unusually clear preview of how he could greet any disappointing results for his party in November, when control of Congress is at stake.

He has been anything but subtle about his desire to limit the ability of Democrats to vote by mail, implying, with no evidence, that simply choosing that widely used means of casting a ballot is inherently suspect. Addressing a gathering of Republican lawmakers in March, he said the way to hold their majority was to pass a strict voter identification law cracking down on mail ballots.

“It’ll guarantee the midterms,” he told them, warning that failure would bring “big trouble.”

Privately, according to one senior adviser, he has pressed aides

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PRIMARIES Coverage of contests in four states, including Maine’s Senate race, is at nytimes.com.

Paxton’s Bid Raises the Stakes in His Voting War

By JAZMINE ULLOA
and EDGAR SANDOVAL

SAN ANTONIO — For years, Ken Paxton, the Texas attorney general, has been waging war on Democratic and Latino-led groups over “election integrity,” leaving a trail of ransacked residences, shellshocked volunteers, struggling organizations and indictments behind him.

But the stakes of the fight with groups determined to mobilize Texas’ fast-growing Hispanic electorate changed significantly last month when he won the Republican Party’s nomination for Senate. Now it is personal and could help determine his own po-

Texas Senate Hopeful Has Been Targeting Latino Groups

litical future — and which party controls the Senate.

“It doesn’t look good for us,” said Gabriel Rosales, the Texas director for the League of United Latin American Citizens, or LULAC, which is one of the nation’s oldest Latino civil rights organizations. “But we are going to keep fighting.”

Long a voice amplifying baseless claims that noncitizens are

voting in huge numbers, Mr. Paxton went beyond rhetoric in 2024, using a new restrictive voting law to target left-leaning Latino groups and wielding corporate statutes that allow him to target entire organizations, not individual officers or employees.

In the name of election integrity, the Republican-dominated Texas Legislature criminalized what had been fairly routine tools for civic groups, churches and political campaigns, particularly in Latino communities. The new law made it a felony to pay staff or give volunteers benefits — such as stipends or gas money — or to drop by the homes of voters. The

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KIM RAFF FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Friends filmed themselves with turmeric ginger shots at the Ballerina Farm Store in Midway, Utah.

Tradwife’s Store Packs Them In, and Stirs the Pot

By VIVIAN YEE

MIDWAY, Utah — You might recognize Midway, Utah, as the storybook backdrop to Hallmark Christmas movies like “Christmas on Duty.” If you’re from Utah, you might recognize it as the village that looks transplanted from the Swiss Alps, complete with a glockenspiel clock warbling hourly from the town hall.

But if you’re a woman with any degree of susceptibility to gingham aprons, hand-hewn sour-

Way of Life Finds Itself at Center of Debate

dough knives, milk cradling a thick layer of cream, enamel candlestick holders or highly realistic, highly cute asparagus-shaped candles to go in the candlestick holders, you might know Midway for another reason.

You might know it as the home, however reluctant, of the Balle-

rina Farm Store.

Ballerina Farm, which supplies the store, is a working farm about half an hour’s drive away from Midway through the snow-frosted mountains and cow pastures of rural northern Utah. But it’s also a woman — the incarnate imagination of 35-year-old Hannah Neelman, a Juilliard-trained ballerina who gave up dancing to become a farmer and mother of nine.

Ballerina Farm is the brand she built atop warmly lit videos of her-

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U.S. Hits Iran on Coast After Vow of Retaliation For Downed Helicopter

Tensions Spread as Israel Strikes Lebanon

This article is by Eric Schmitt,
Maggie Haberman, Euan Ward and
Michael Levenson.

WASHINGTON — The U.S. military said Tuesday that it was striking Iran again at the direction of President Trump, who had accused the country of shooting down an Army attack helicopter near the Strait of Hormuz. It was the latest sign that a fragile cease-fire was failing to quell the war.

The strikes were “a proportional response to unjustified Iranian aggression,” the U.S. Central Command said.

Iranian state television reported that explosions and air-defense systems were erupting along the country’s Persian Gulf coast, including in Bandar Abbas, Qeshm and Sirik. State television said Sirik and Qeshm had been attacked several times, but did not provide further details.

Two Iranian officials who spoke anonymously in order to discuss sensitive information said the strikes had targeted military and naval bases, radars and missile launchers in five locations on Iran’s southern coast.

Just hours earlier, Mr. Trump said on social media that he had been informed by the U.S. military that Iranian forces had downed the Apache helicopter on Monday night. Both crew members, the pilot and the gunner, were rescued within two hours and were in sta-

ble condition, the military said.

“Nevertheless, the United States must, of necessity, respond to this attack,” Mr. Trump wrote.

His statement came after a flare-up in attacks between Iran and Israel on Sunday and Monday threatened to push the Middle East back into a wider war.

Iran did not admit or deny downing the Apache helicopter. But the foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said on social media that forces operating close to Iran were at “constant risk on account of their own human errors, plain accidents, or potentially being caught in crossfire.”

“To reduce risk, best solution is for them to leave,” he wrote. “We prefer language of diplomacy but speak other languages too.”

The U.S. attacks came as Israeli forces pounded southern Lebanon as they fought Hezbollah, the Iranian-backed militia, despite a new U.S.-brokered cease-fire in that country.

Lebanon’s health ministry said the latest Israeli airstrikes had killed at least eight people and wounded dozens more in Tyre, one of southern Lebanon’s largest cities and a UNESCO World Heritage site renowned for its ancient Roman ruins.

The fighting on multiple fronts in recent days has underscored how difficult the intertwined con-

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Light Pollution May Be Making Allergies Worse

By MARTA ZARASKA

If you live in a big, brightly lit city and you feel like allergy season just never ends, you might be right: New research shows that light pollution prompts plants to shed pollen longer, increases the growth of notoriously allergenic ragweed and makes our bodies more prone to allergic reactions, from runny noses to asthma.

The study, published in the journal PNAS Nexus, focused on the Northeast and found that trees in cities like New York and Philadelphia start producing pollen earlier in the spring and finish later in the fall compared with places in the same region with low light pollution. The difference could add up to 130 days per year to the allergy season, the researchers found.

Light pollution is widespread: Almost 80 percent of North Americans cannot perceive the Milky Way because of sources like streetlights, car headlights and illuminated billboards. Beyond washing out the stars, all of that light appears to change the physiology of living organisms, humans and ragweed included.

“Plants often use things like how long a day is in order to make decisions about when they flower or unfurl their leaves,” said Daniel Katz, a plant ecologist at Cornell University and an author of the study. The paper built on research findings that plants in light-polluted areas produce leaves earlier in the spring and lose them later in the fall.

“We’ve basically tricked plants into making decisions they wouldn’t ordinarily make,” Dr. Katz said.

Dr. Katz and his colleagues used nighttime light data from satellites and airborne pollen counts spanning more than a decade and found that, in places like New York City, the allergy season often starts before March 1, compared with darker areas like rural Con-

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GRANT HINDSLEY FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Ron Cardiel brings a “no-escape mentality” to preaching.

World Cup Fans To Get an Earful From Preachers

By ANNA GRIFFIN

SEATTLE — World Cup fans who crowd into Seattle from around the world this month will find new self-cleaning public toilets and a floating watch party on Elliott Bay — and men in black telling them, at earsplitting volume, that they’re going to hell if they don’t repent.

Evangelical Christian street preachers have become a fixture at Seattle’s biggest public events, drawing angry complaints from sports teams, arts organizations and neighborhood leaders who say the ministry’s powerful portable speakers can overwhelm concerts, festivals and ballgames. Efforts to curb them have been no match for the preachers’ savvy approach to avoiding legal trouble, coupled with Seattle’s commitment to free speech.

Now the ministers are preparing for the prospect of 750,000 soccer fans descending on the city, many of them to cheer on Iran, Egypt, Qatar, and Bosnia and Herzegovina, all Muslim-majority countries with games scheduled in the city.

“It’s an incredible opportunity,” said Justin Symons, a preacher with Gospel Invasion Ministries,

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A Troubled Visa Program

Farms need legal migrant labor, but preventing abuses in the H-2A program is proving difficult. PAGE B1

OpenAI Files to Go Public

The company hopes to raise billions in an offering that could unlock a new generation of tech wealth. PAGE B1

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Accused of Smuggling Mpox

A Dutch virologist for the N.I.H. was stopped at the Detroit airport after working in Congo. His lawyer said the material was for research. PAGE A4

Neighbors Dragged Into Fight

Drones launched by both Russia and Ukraine are veering off course, menacing nations that are not at war. PAGE A6

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Mayor Who Was Foreign Agent

What could Beijing want from Eileen Wang, the former leader of a small city in Southern California? PAGE A11



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New Voyage for ‘The Last Ship’

The musical by Sting failed on Broadway in 2014, but he has brought a revised version to the Met Opera. PAGE C1

Trove of Frida Kahlo Artworks

What may be the world’s largest collection of the artist’s paintings has emerged in a Mexican museum. PAGE C1

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Young and Loving the Knicks

New Yorkers under 30 have a notion of the suffering that older fans had endured, but are much more focused on celebrating a charge toward an N.B.A. championship. PAGE B11

Back, and in Winning Form

Serena Williams, 44, in her first professional tennis match since 2022, teamed with Victoria Mboko for a straight-sets victory in a Wimbledon warm-up tournament. PAGE B12

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Bret Stephens

PAGE A19



FOOD D1-8

Making High School Memories

Promgoers are reinventing the themes and clothes — and menus — that are used in an American rite of passage. We visit five of the events. PAGE D7

